captured and had his nose and one hand cut off. After a year without a nose, he and four others submitted themselves to an Indian surgeon who used skin from their foreheads to repair the noses. We know little about the surgeon but two senior British surgeons from Bombay Presidency witnessed this operation and sent back detailed descriptions and diagrams. The publication in Europe in 1816 of their account would give birth to modern plastic surgery.

Of course, all the cultural and intellectual activity of this period was not limited to the Gangetic heartland. Take for example Panini, the famous grammarian, who standardized the Sanskrit language during the fifth century BC. He is said to have been born in Gandhara (eastern Afghanistan) and to have lived in Taxila (near modern Islamabad). This part of the subcontinent was about to witness the first attempt by a European power to conquer India.

THE EMPIRE OF THE LION

The world of small tribal kingdoms described above went through a major shift in the third and fourth century BC. This happened almost simultaneously across the ancient world. It was not so much a change in technology as a shift in political ideology and ambition. Within a couple of generations, we see the idea of empire inspire a series of remarkable leaders around the world, whose conquests would redefine the political geography of the world.

The first of the empire-builders was Cyrus the Great of Persia in the sixth century BC, but it is only in the fourth century that we begin to see empire-building on a totally different scale. In China, King Hui of Qin began a cycle of conquest around 330 BC that would culminate in the first empire under Shi Huangdi a century later. At around the same time, Alexander the Great would take control of Greece, Egypt, the Levant, Mesopotamia, Bactria and Persia. Then in the winter of 327-326 BC he marched into India. Here he built an alliance with Ambhi, the king of Taxila. Together they defeated Porus on the banks of the Jhelum. It is possible that the name